

HAMBURG MARITIME MUSEUM

Conservation and Collection Department

CONSERVATION ASSESSMENT REPORT

Site NF-7, North Frisian Medieval Wreck Survey, Phase 3 Finds

Report reference: HMM-CONS-2025-NF7

Prepared by: Dr. Frida Moe, Curator of Maritime Collections

Date: 18.11.2025

1. Introduction

This assessment covers the 84 finds transferred from Site NF-7 to Hamburg Maritime Museum following the conclusion of the 2025 field season. The finds were received on 12 September 2025 and 08 October 2025 (second shipment, including NF7-014 planking section). Individual condition assessments were completed by 31 October 2025. This report summarises condition grades, treatment plans, and repository arrangements, and is provided to project PI Prof. Dr. Gloria Gross for inclusion in the DFG Phase 3 Final Report.

2. Condition Summary

Condition grade	Description	Count
A - Good	Stable, no immediate treatment required	16
B - Fair	Stable with treatment in progress or planned	42
C - Poor	Actively deteriorating; treatment commenced immediately	19
D - Critical	High risk; specialist treatment ongoing	7
Total		84

3. Treatment Overview

3.1 Iron Fastenings (22 finds, condition C and D)

All 22 iron finds are undergoing electrolytic desalination in the museum's desalination tanks. The high chloride content typical of North Sea waterlogged iron requires extended treatment, anticipated at 18 months minimum for the larger fasteners. Interim monitoring is scheduled every 6 weeks. Six of the seven condition-D finds are concentrated in this category.

3.2 Organic Material - Timbers and Planking (31 finds, condition A-C)

The timber assemblage includes the significant NF7-014 plank section and 30 additional structural pieces. All timber is held in freshwater tanks with controlled ion replacement. Polyethylene glycol (PEG) consolidation is planned for the two largest pieces, NF7-014 and NF7-028. Preliminary dendrochronology samples have been dispatched to Caledonia Maritime University. Drying of the smaller timber fragments will commence after desalination of associated iron fastenings, to avoid differential stress.

3.3 Rope and Organic Textiles (7 finds, condition B-C)

Seven rope and rigging fragments are undergoing freeze-drying in the museum's lyophilisation facility. This is the preferred treatment for hemp-based organic material from the North Sea waterlogged environment. Two fragments show partial mineralisation, which is preserved as evidence of the original manufacturing technique.

3.4 Ceramics (9 finds, condition A-B)

The ceramic assemblage is the most stable category. Desalination in freshwater is complete for all nine finds. Detailed examination and photographic recording has been completed. A report on the ceramic typology is being prepared by Prof. Dr. Gloria Gross for incorporation into the project monograph.

4. Repository Arrangements

All 84 NF-7 Phase 3 finds are held by Hamburg Maritime Museum under the terms of the Lending and Conservation Agreement (HMM-CHM-22). Legal ownership remains with the relevant heritage authority under German law. Long-term repository has been agreed with the museum pending publication and any future exhibition decisions.

Access to the finds during the active treatment period is by appointment with Dr. Frida Moe. The PI has unrestricted access at all times with prior notification. Access for third parties, including academic collaborators and students, is by written request to the museum, cc to the PI.

5. Exhibition Proposals

The museum has received a preliminary proposal from the PI for a temporary exhibition featuring the NF-7 finds, provisionally titled "Ships of the Hanse: Evidence from the North Sea Floor". The proposal is currently under internal museum review. Any public display of the finds will be subject to conservation condition confirmation at the time of exhibition planning. The finds will not be available for public display before the treatment programme for the iron assemblage is complete, anticipated no earlier than late 2027.

6. Next Assessment

A follow-up condition assessment will be conducted in February 2026 to review treatment progress on the condition-D finds and to update the treatment timeline for the timber assemblage. A copy of the follow-up assessment will be provided to Prof. Dr. Gloria Gross for the DFG Phase 4 reporting archive.

Signed: Dr. Frida Moe, Curator of Maritime Collections, Hamburg Maritime Museum

Countersigned: Prof. Dr. Gloria Gross, Principal Investigator, Nordmeier Maritime University